YAOTIAN (JUSTIN) ZHANG

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EDUCATION

University of Nebraska–Lincoln — Lincoln, NE, USA
Ph.D. in Economics — 2026–present (expected 2031)

University of Macau — Macau, China
B.Sc. in Economics — 2020–2024

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Labor Economics, Public Economics, Urban and Spatial Economics, Economics of Education

RESEARCH

"Green Borders: Cross-Border Enforcement Spillovers from Cannabis Legalization"
Working paper.

"Place-Based College Admission and the Geography of Graduates: Evidence from China"
In progress.

"Big Fish, Small Pond, Far Away: High School Rank and Adult Migration"
In progress.

"Admission Policy and the Spatial Allocation of Talent: A Dynamic Model of College and Location Choice"
In progress.

"Disappearing First Rungs: Generative AI, Entry-Level Jobs, and the Geography of Career Ladders"
In progress.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Bureau of Business Research, University of Nebraska–Lincoln — 2026–present
Graduate Research Assistant to Eric Thompson

- Measure skills gaps and education–occupation mismatch across Nebraska labor markets using ACS microdata.

Faculty of Social Sciences, University of Macau — 2023–2024
Research Assistant

- Collected and cleaned data on online political content; replicated machine learning workflows in R.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, Graduate Workshops on Causal Inference and Research Methods — Summer 2025
Hong Kong Metropolitan University

Teaching Assistant, Introductory R Programming — Spring 2024
Lui Che Woo College, University of Macau

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

Carpenter Fellowship, College of Business, University of Nebraska–Lincoln — 2026
Graduate Research Assistantship, Department of Economics, University of Nebraska–Lincoln — 2026–2027
Dean's Honour List (top 10%), Faculty of Social Sciences, University of Macau — 2023, 2024

SKILLS

Programming: R, Stata, Python, LaTeX, ArcGIS
Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native), English (fluent)

REFERENCES

Available upon request.